STABILIZER MISTAKE CHECK

Two minutes before the real garment. Three questions pick the backing, four checks protect it, and the mistakes below are the ones that cause most puckering, shifting, and sinking.

If the fabric stretches, the backing stays. If it holds its shape, the backing can leave.

THREE QUESTIONS, IN ORDER

1. **Does it stretch?** Pull both ways. It gives and springs back: the backing has to stay in the garment, cut-away family. It holds its shape: tear-away is on the table for lighter designs.
2. **How hard is the design working?** Big and dense pulls harder and wants more support: heavier weight or a second layer. Small and open needs less.
3. **What is on the surface?** Loops, fuzz, or texture (fleece, towels): add water-soluble topping over the design so stitches sit on top. Smooth and flat: skip it.

THE HOOP CHECK

- ☐ Backing cut bigger than the hoop, past the edges on every side.
- ☐ Smallest hoop that fits the design comfortably.
- ☐ Fabric smooth and snug in its natural state, never stretched tight. Stretched now means puckered later.
- ☐ Fabric and backing sitting together as one layer, no shifting between them.
- ☐ Test stitch on the closest scrap to the real fabric, then read it before the garment goes on.

THE MISTAKES, AND THE FIX

- ☐ **Tear-away under a stretchy garment.** Support leaves, design warps in the wash. Use cut-away.
- ☐ **Fabric hooped drum tight.** Perfect in the hoop, rippled on the table. Hoop it natural, let the backing hold.
- ☐ **Backing ends inside the hoop.** The design edge stitches unsupported. Cut it past the hoop.
- ☐ **One light layer, one big dense design.** Fabric pulls in from every side. Heavier backing or a second layer.
- ☐ **No topping on pile.** Stitches sink and edges go ragged. Topping on top, backing underneath.
- ☐ **Three changes at once.** Clean test, no idea why. One change, one test.

READ THE TEST STITCH

- ☐ **Puckers all around:** backing too light for the design, or fabric was stretched hooping.
- ☐ **Puckers only after you unhoop:** it was stretched in the hoop. That is the tell.
- ☐ **Outline off the fill, gaps opening:** fabric crept. Firmer hoop, smaller hoop, layers together.
- ☐ **Stitches buried in the surface:** surface problem, not a backing problem. Add topping.
- ☐ **Design warps after washing:** the support left and the fabric could not carry it. Switch to cut-away.

Stretch picks the family. The design picks how much. The surface picks the topping. One change, one test.